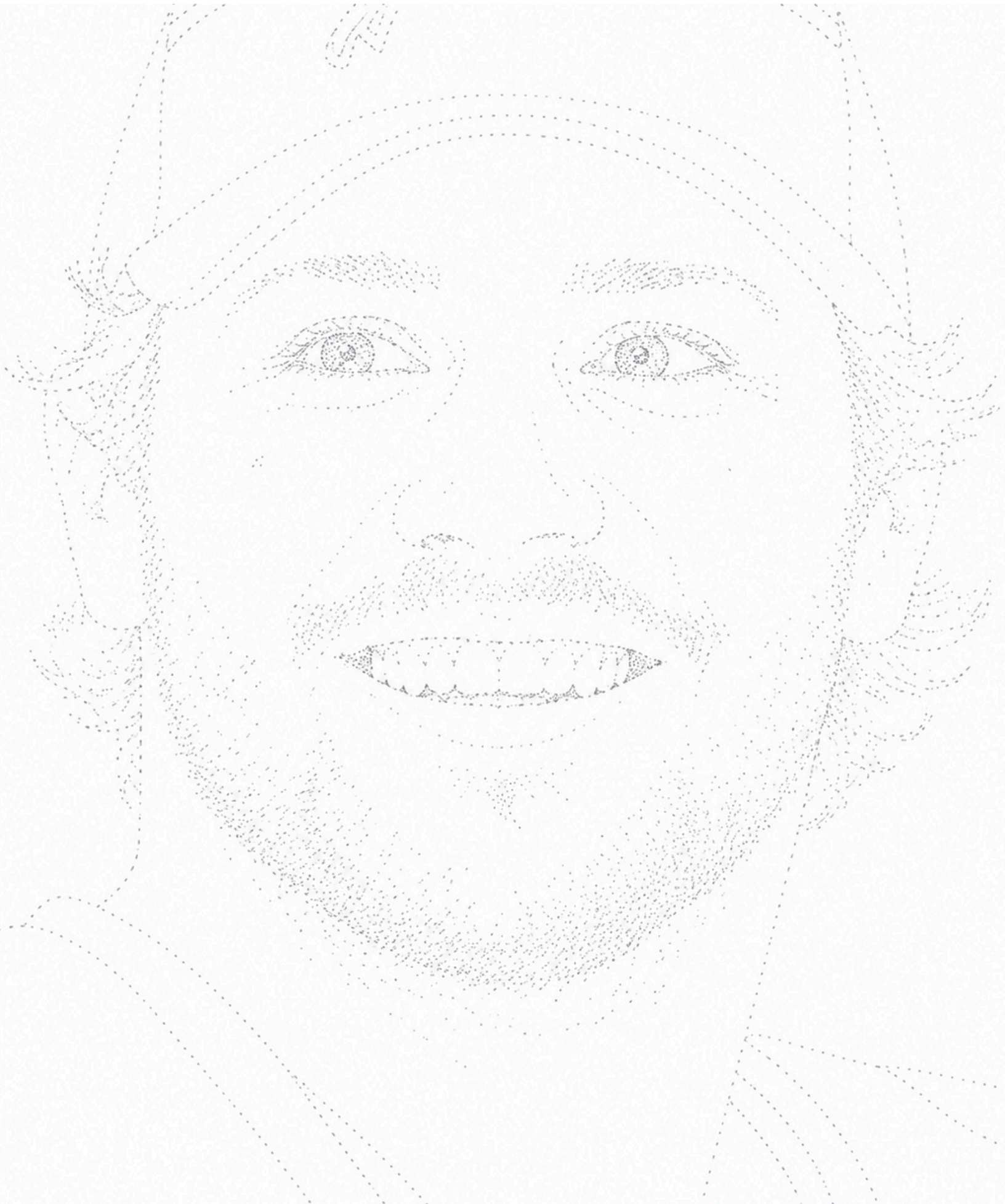


Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



Portrait Guide #019

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10-12 hours

Subject A young athlete wearing a blue baseball cap and white athletic top with blue and orange striping, with loose curly hair partially visible around the cap edges, displaying a calm neutral expression with warm medium-deep skin tone.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



Nectar

PC1092

primary light skin tone, warm moderately saturated red-orange base



Henna

PC1031

mid-value warm skin undertone and foundation layer



Beige Sienna

PC1080

light warm skin highlight, cheek and nose glow zones



Peach

PC939

very light subsurface scattering, peak highlights and cheek warmth



Chestnut

PC1081

mid-value warm shadow foundation, jaw and cheekbone depth



Espresso

PC1099

dark chromatic shadow anchor, eye cast shadow, core shadow and pupil



Periwinkle

PC1025

cool dark complementary tone for shadow depth and iris definition



China Blue

PC1100

mid-value saturated blue for iris radiance and cap base



Blue Lake

PC1102

bright light blue for iris mid-layer and cap highlights



Caribbean Sea

PC1103

light cyan-blue for sclera and atmospheric warmth in cool zones



Carmine Red

PC926

saturated red core for lips and orange striping on garment



Clay Rose

PC1017

warm grey undertone for skin transitions and soft shadow blending



Light Umber

PC941

soft warm shadow and blending tone, hair mid-value



70% French Grey

PC1074

neutral warm shadow undertone, value map foundation



Cream

PC914

burnishing highlight for peak lights and final luminosity



White

PC938

final burnish peak highlights and specular point on eyes



20% Cool Grey

PC1060

light neutral for white garment base and cool cast areas



Blush Pink

PC928

subsurface scattering warmth on ears, cheeks and vascular zones

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Soft, diffused natural light from the front-side, suggesting overcast conditions or soft window light; creates gradual terminator on rounded forms and subtle shadow modeling without harsh contrast.

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex, bridge and tip of nose, peaks of cheekbones, centre of lower lip, cap crown; characterized by hard value jump and warm, light tone.

LIGHT AREA

Upper face plane, lit side of cheeks, temple areas, exposed neck and chin, upper chest; evenly lit with soft gradation.

MIDTONE

Overall face and neck, sides of nose, upper eyelids, transitional zones between light and shadow, establishing the dominant value range.

SHADOW

Under cheekbones creating soft self-shadow, beneath jaw line, cast shadow from brow ridge over upper eye, recesses and underside of cap.

CAST SHADOW

Upper eyelid cast shadow creates eye depth; soft shadow under jawline and on neck underside; subtle shadows within cap interior.

Edge quality notes

Soft edges overall due to diffused light; terminators are gradual on rounded forms (cheeks, nose, chin). The lash line is the sharpest edge in the face. Cap silhouette is crisp. Hair edges are broken and diffuse, merging into background. Garment edges are defined but soft. Background is lost and minimal.

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

OI Step 1: Value Map & Light Anchor

Entire face, neck and visible areas including cap and garment

Circular strokes in light areas, directional strokes following shadow contours and form, very light pressure throughout, deliberate white paper showing in highlights.

Light pressure

- Establish the full range of values — from highlight to shadow — at very light pressure using warm-neutral grey-ochre. Coloured pencil cannot be lightened once pigment is down, so value hierarchy must precede local colour and guides all depth to follow.
- Block the highlight areas (forehead apex, nose bridge, cheekbone peaks, lower lip) as the **LIGHTEST** zones — leave bare paper or feather only the palest touch; these are your value ceiling and will anchor all darker values below.
- Lightly establish the midtone plane across the majority of the face, neck and cap-edge zones using even pressure in circular strokes to preserve paper tooth for the layering still to come.
- Feather shadows (under jaw, under cheekbones, eye sockets, cast shadow from brow) at medium-light pressure; maintain a warm undertone in all shadows — avoid cool or neutral grey, which reads as absence of light.
- Use PC1074 (70% French Grey) at ultra-light pressure as your warm-toned value anchor; this neutral with a warm undertone will guide the depth of subsequent layers without committing to local colour too early.

COLORS ● PC1074 70% French Grey

↔ PC1074 (70% French Grey) anchors value with a warm undertone — any light neutral grey (PC1059 10% Cool Grey, PC1050 10% Warm Grey) works, but favour warm grey to avoid ashy shadows.

STOP WHEN

The full value range is visible from near-white highlights to light grey-brown shadows · the pencil is gliding and not catching or dragging, and you can still see individual paper texture.

✦ *Do not fill every square inch — deliberate white paper showing through the highlights now makes them **BRIGHTER** when you layer colour overtop, because the eye compares pigment to bare paper nearby. A highlight fully covered in light colour looks dull; a colour layer over bright white reads brilliant.*

02 Step 2: Base Skin Tones & Warm Undertones

Entire face and visible neck, building depth across two coordinated passes

Circular strokes in light even passes, pressure light-to-medium, following the roundness of facial forms, feathering into value anchors.

Light to Medium pressure

- Skin scatters light and reflects its surroundings; a single 'skin colour' pencil is always too flat and dead. Build prismatic depth by layering distinct hues that the eye optically fuses into luminous, three-dimensional skin.
- First pass — Light warm foundation: Apply PC1092 (Nectar) in soft circular strokes across the entire face and neck at light-to-medium pressure, building even coverage without overworking. This warm light red-orange sets the dominant tone and ensures no ashy grey undertone creeps in. Feather into highlights and soften into shadow zones so no hard edges appear yet.
- Second pass, once the first layer is set — Undertone and temperature shift: Layer PC1031 (Henna) selectively into the midtones and shadow transitions (cheek planes, jawline, sides of nose, upper neck) using circular strokes at light pressure. This mid-value warm tone begins the three-dimensional colour shift and prevents the flat appearance of a single-pencil skin.
- Preserve the paper tooth after this pass — do NOT burnish or overwork — because many warm and cool layers are still to come. The slight graininess now is your asset, not a flaw; it holds pigment and reads as luminous depth.

COLORS



PC1092 Nectar



PC1031 Henna

↔ PC1092 (Nectar) is the warm light base — PC1080 (Beige Sienna) is slightly deeper but carries the same warm red-orange, or layer PC939 (Peach) and PC1031 (Henna) together. PC1031 (Henna) is the warm mid-tone undertone — PC1081 (Chestnut) is slightly darker but works; avoid greys here.

STOP WHEN

A warm, even glow covers the entire face and neck in two distinct but blended layers · the paper still has visible tooth texture and the pencil is sliding smoothly without catching or dragging.

✦ *The measured skin sits at L*54/100 and is dominantly warm golden-olive. If your base feels too light or too pink-salmon after these two passes, you are building correctly — it will deepen with the mid-value and shadow layers to follow, and the warmth now ensures the final depth reads golden, not cool or grey.*

03 Step 3: Eyes — Sclera, Pupil Structure & Upper-Lid Cast Shadow

Both eyes: sclera, pupils, upper-eyelid shadow and lash-line foundation

Small circular strokes in the sclera, directional strokes for the upper-lid shadow following the brow contour, light pressure, feathering to avoid hard edges.

Light to Medium pressure

- The eye reads depth and life from its darkest dark (upper lash line and pupil) and its brightest light (the specular highlight). A flat or mid-value eye looks vacant; establish the light-shadow hierarchy first, then layer colour into it.
- Block the pupils as small dark circles using PC1099 (Espresso) at light pressure, offset slightly upward and inward where light typically catches the eye; avoid perfect roundness or central placement, which reads as vacant.
- Establish the upper-eyelid cast shadow as a soft darker zone above each eye using PC1099 (Espresso) at light-medium pressure, feathering downward so the shadow gradates into the brow and does not create a hard black line. This shadow sits directly over the iris and gives the eye recession and depth.
- Lay the sclera (white of the eye) as very pale, cool-toned using PC1060 (20% Cool Grey) or PC1103 (Caribbean Sea) at ultra-light pressure — sclera is NEVER pure white, but a soft cool-white that recedes and allows the iris to advance. Feather away from the pupil so the sclera is cleanest near the pupil and slightly tinted at the outer corner.
- Reserve the specular highlight (the bright dot) for the final burnish pass; placing it now kills the layering structure and traps you in a single bright zone.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1060 20% Cool Grey

● PC1103 Caribbean Sea

↔ PC1099 (Espresso) provides the dark pupil and shadow depth; PC1025 (Periwinkle) also works as a cool dark. PC1060 (20% Cool Grey) and PC1103 (Caribbean Sea) are the pale cool tones for sclera — PC1023 (Cloud Blue) at very light pressure works, or layer only paper with a hint of cool.

STOP WHEN

Each eye has a recessed appearance with a soft shadow above and a pale cool sclera below the pupil · you can still see the individual paper texture and the surface is not blended yet.

✦ *The sclera shadow (the softer, cooler region on the far side of the iris from the light) is where you'll later add subtle cool tone; leave it slightly more visible here than the near side so the eye reads as a sphere, not a flat circle with no volume.*

04 Step 4: Eyes — Iris Radiance & Blue Layering

Both irises: layering the measured blue tones with radial structure

Radial strokes emanating from pupil outward, tapering toward the iris edge, light pressure throughout, following the wheel-spoke structure of the real iris.

Light pressure

- The iris is a translucent disc with concentric zones of colour and radial striations. Layering from dark centre outward creates depth and luminosity that a flat fill cannot achieve; preserve the light, striated quality.
- Over the pupil (now dark), apply PC1100 (China Blue) in fine radial strokes emanating outward from the pupil like wheel spokes, at light pressure. Strokes should taper as they move outward, mimicking how real iris striations fade. This layer is cool blue and begins the iris's chromatic richness.
- Second layer, once the first blue is set: Apply PC1102 (Blue Lake) in a softer radial pattern over the outer iris rim at light-medium pressure, so the iris becomes cooler and more saturated at the edge. This creates the subtle iris limbus (the dark ring at the iris edge) and makes the iris appear to curve away from the viewer.
- The iris measured colour sits at hue 216–222deg and is distinctly cool blue, not blue-violet or purple. Use the measured blue hue consistently — do not drift toward purple or navy, or the eyes will read as cold rather than cool and alive.
- Keep pressure light and strokes directional (radial, not circular) to allow paper tooth to show through; a blended, burnished iris looks plastic and opaque instead of luminous.

COLORS

● PC1100 China Blue

● PC1102 Blue Lake

↔ PC1100 (China Blue) is the saturated blue for iris core; PC1027 (Peacock Blue) is a close alternative. PC1102 (Blue Lake) and PC1103 (Caribbean Sea) build the outer iris — either works, or layer both for maximum saturation; do not use PC1025 (Periwinkle) here as it darkens toward the pupil.

STOP WHEN

The iris has visible radial striations radiating outward from the pupil · the pencil is gliding without resistance and strokes remain individually visible with paper texture showing.

✦ *Blue eyes in coloured pencil fail when artists default to purple-blue or misread the measured hue. The measured data gives you the truth — blue at hue 216deg+, not purple at 240deg+. Trust the measurement over your impression of the photo.*

05 Step 5: Shadows, Form & Chromatic Depth

Core shadows around cheekbones, jaw, sides of nose, around eyes and ear; the away-side cheek plane

Directional strokes following form contour (downward on jaw, inward on cheek), medium pressure for warm shadow base, light pressure for cool glaze, preserving crisp terminator edges on cheekbone.

Medium for warm shadow, Light for cool glaze pressure

- Value carries form; shadows must be DEEP enough to read three-dimensional and three-directional. Under warm light with cool ambient, warm skin casts cool-rimmed shadows, but 'cool' is never neutral grey — chromatic shadows stay warm in the core and cool only at the final edge.
- Apply PC1081 (Chestnut) selectively into the core shadow zones (beneath cheekbone, along the jaw terminator, into the neck shadow under the jaw) at medium pressure, using directional strokes that follow the form — downward along the jaw, inward toward the nose. This warm mid-dark anchors the shadow depth without committing to cool.
- Layer PC1025 (Periwinkle) or PC1099 (Espresso) as a cool glaze INSIDE the core shadow zones at light pressure — apply selectively at the deepest point of the terminator and the darkest corner shadows, not everywhere. This cool tone contrasts with the warm midtone nearby, making the shadow appear three-dimensional and the lit plane more luminous by contrast.
- The away-side cheek plane (the side of the face turning away from light) must be explicitly deeper and cooler than the lit side and read as its own mid-value form plane. Use PC1081 (Chestnut) or PC941 (Light Umber) at medium pressure across the entire away-side plane, then establish ONE crisp core-shadow edge (the terminator on the cheekbone) separating it from the lit cheek.
- Never blur or soften the core shadow edge itself; it marks where the form turns and must be readable. Soften shadows INSIDE and BEHIND the terminator, creating a gradient from cool dark to warm midtone.

COLORS

● PC1081 Chestnut

● PC1025 Periwinkle

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC941 Light Umber

↔ PC1081 (Chestnut) is the warm shadow base; PC1031 (Henna) or PC941 (Light Umber) work similarly. PC1025 (Periwinkle) is the cool complement; PC1099 (Espresso) or PC1100 (China Blue) at very light pressure also work — avoid pure grey.

STOP WHEN

The face reads three-dimensional with a lit plane, a distinct terminator and a cooler away-side plane; the core shadows are deep but still carry the warm undertone of the base · the pencil drags slightly on the medium-pressure shadow pass, indicating good tooth consumption.

✦ A common failure is making the shadow too ashy or cool all the way through. The solution: keep the *FIRST* layer warm, then glaze cool tone *ONLY* at the deepest point, leaving a warm-to-cool gradient inside the shadow. This is what subsurface scattering looks like — the edge is cooler, the interior is warmer.

06 Step 6: Hair — Curly Texture & Visible Edges Under Cap

Visible curly hair texture around cap edges (sides, back, forehead edge margins)

Short curved strokes following curl direction, clustered in groups, pressure medium, feathering outward toward the tips and perimeter edges.

Light to Medium pressure

- Hair is never one flat value or one colour. It has a density gradient (darkest at the core, lighter toward the tips), warm and cool undertones across its mass, and a sheen band where light grazes. Render the light pattern across the mass, not individual strands.
- The subject wears loose curly hair under the blue cap, with texture visible at the edges. Treat each visible curl cluster as its own mass with its own stroke direction following the curve of the coil — around the form, not down it. Curly hair wraps and bends; your strokes should wrap too.
- Base layer — curly hair shadow and density: Use PC1099 (Espresso) or PC1031 (Henna) at light-medium pressure, applying short curved strokes in clusters following the curl pattern. Darkest core is at the base (nearest the scalp and cap) and lightens toward the curl tips. Leave gaps between clusters to show the scalp and cap edge beneath.
- Second layer — mid-value and depth: Apply PC941 (Light Umber) or PC1081 (Chestnut) between and over the dark core clusters at medium pressure, building the mid-value that makes curls read as dimensional rather than flat. A few fine strokes of PC1025 (Periwinkle) at light pressure in the deepest recesses between curls add chromatic depth.
- Reserve highlights — use very light pressure or skip the tips entirely here; burnish a few light, thin highlights last in the final step. Curly hair has a broken, diffuse edge where it meets the cap or background; never frame it with a hard line.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1031 Henna

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC1081 Chestnut

● PC1025 Periwinkle

↔ PC1099 (Espresso) is the dark core base; PC1031 (Henna) or PC1082 (Chocolate) work similarly (stay warm-toned). PC941 (Light Umber) builds the mid-value; PC1081 (Chestnut) or PC1084 (Ginger Root) substitute. PC1025 (Periwinkle) adds cool depth; PC1100 (China Blue) works.

STOP WHEN

Visible curls have dimension with dark cores and lighter mid-value tips, readable as separate clusters · the pencil is gliding smoothly and individual strokes are visible, not blended into a uniform dark mass.

✦ *Curly hair under a hat often appears as separate ringlets or clusters visible at the edges. The failure is treating it as one 'hair mass' and blending it smooth. Preserve*

individual curl clusters so the eye reads the hair as textured and loose, not matted or slicked down. Each cluster is a separate volume.

07 Step 7: Cap, Garment & Neck Transition

Blue baseball cap, white athletic top with blue and orange striping, neck and skin-to-garment transition zone

Curved strokes following form on cap, light pressure for white garment glaze, directional strokes for garment stripe placement, soft feathering at skin-to-garment edge, medium pressure for neck shadow.

Light to Medium pressure

- Garments and headwear are lit forms, not fill; they carry light, shadow and fabric texture just as skin does. The cap casts shadow on the face and hair, and its colour bounces onto the lower jaw and neck; the garment's colour bounces onto the neck.
- Cap base layer: Apply PC1100 (China Blue) or PC1102 (Blue Lake) at light-medium pressure across the visible cap surface, following its crown form with curved strokes. Leave the brightest highlight (top or sun-side of the cap) mostly bare paper or feather only the palest layer. The cap's shadow side (back or underside near the brim) takes PC1025 (Periwinkle) or PC1099 (Espresso) at medium pressure to read as recessed.
- Garment base layer: Apply PC1060 (20% Cool Grey) at light pressure across the white top as a very pale glaze — white fabric is never pure paper white; it carries a cool grey undertone in shadow and reflects the sky. Leave the lit upper chest and shoulders mostly white with only the palest layer.
- Orange striping (blue stripes and orange accent stripes): Layer PC1100 (China Blue) for blue stripes and PC926 (Carmine Red) for the orange stripes at light-medium pressure. These are small saturated areas; keep them crisp and legible. The striping is the garment's LOCAL COLOUR and draws the eye.
- Neck transition — a form plane: Model the neck with a subtle core shadow on the underside (where it meets the jaw, using PC1081 Chestnut at light-medium pressure) and ensure the skin-to-garment edge is soft and integrated. The blue of the cap or the orange of the garment bounces faintly onto the lower jaw and neck — glaze a whisper of PC1100 (China Blue) or PC926 (Carmine Red) at ultra-light pressure onto the jaw margin where it meets the shirt, so the garment reads as reflecting light onto the skin.
- Do NOT overwork the garment yet; keep it broad and soft. Folds, fabric texture and fine striping come in the detail step.

COLORS  PC1100 China Blue  PC1102 Blue Lake  PC1025 Periwinkle

 PC1099 Espresso  PC1060 20% Cool Grey  PC926 Carmine Red

 PC1081 Chestnut

↔ PC1100 (China Blue) and PC1102 (Blue Lake) build cap blue — use whichever is on hand. PC1025 (Periwinkle) is dark blue-toned shadow; PC1099 (Espresso) works if you need a neutral dark. PC1060 (20% Cool Grey) is the white fabric base; any pale cool grey substitutes. PC926 (Carmine Red) is the orange stripe; PC925 (Crimson Lake) or PC924 (Crimson Red) work similarly.

STOP WHEN

The cap reads as a three-dimensional form with light and shadow, and the white garment sits light with visible stripes · the pencil is gliding at light-medium pressure and you can still see paper texture between strokes.

✦ *Beginners often leave the garment completely white and untouched, making it float disconnected from the skin. Even a whisper of the cap's blue or the shirt stripe's orange bouncing onto the jaw margin anchors the portrait and unifies the composition. The bounce colour is VERY light — 10% or less of the pigment intensity used on the garment itself.*

08 Step 8: Cheeks, Nose & Subsurface Scattering Warmth

Cheekbone peaks, nose tip and sides, ears, bridge of nose, cheek and nostril transitions

Circular strokes on cheeks and nose tip, layered warmth building from light to medium pressure, soft blending into midtones, very light pressure for red accents on nostril.

Light to Medium pressure

- Skin scatters light, especially in thin or vascular areas — the nose tip, cheeks, ears and inner eyelids glow warm red-orange even in shadow, reading as alive blood flow rather than reflected light. This subsurface scattering is the difference between a portrait that breathes and one that looks plastic.
- Apply PC939 (Peach) or PC928 (Blush Pink) selectively on the cheekbone peaks (the highest point where light grazes the form) and the nose tip at light-medium pressure. These areas are LIGHTER and WARMER than the surrounding skin plane; they sit at the boundary of light and shadow where the form curves.
- On the sides of the nose and the inner side of the nostrils (if visible), layer PC1080 (Beige Sienna) or PC1092 (Nectar) at medium pressure — the nose is thinner and more translucent here, so the warm undertone becomes more visible. A hint of red (PC926 Carmine Red at ultra-light pressure) can glaze the nostril rim if the photo shows it.
- Ears (if visible at the cap edge): Apply the same cheek warmth — PC939 (Peach) or PC928 (Blush Pink) — to the outer rim and the inner ear, as ears are extremely vascular and glow warm. They often catch reflected light from garment or hair and become even warmer and more saturated.
- Blend these warm layers with circular strokes into the surrounding midtone, but do NOT over-blend into mud; the transition should be a soft gradient, not a hard edge and not a muddy grey middle. Keep at least one slightly defined rim where the cheek glow meets the core shadow.
- Step back and assess: If cheeks read too pink or too saturated, soften with a very light glaze of the surrounding skin tone (PC1031 Henna or PC1092 Nectar), but do not grey them out. Pink is more forgivable than ashy.

COLORS

● PC939 Peach

● PC928 Blush Pink

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1092 Nectar

● PC926 Carmine Red

↔ PC939 (Peach) is the warm glow on peaks; PC1080 (Beige Sienna) or PC928 (Blush Pink) work similarly (stay warm-toned, never cool or ashy). PC926 (Carmine Red) adds depth to the nostril or cheek shadow rim; PC1030 (Raspberry) or PC1001 (Salmon Pink) substitute if needed.

STOP WHEN

Cheekbone peaks and nose tip glow noticeably warmer and lighter than the surrounding face, with a soft readable transition · the blending strokes are gliding

smoothly and paper texture is still visible, not yet burnished.

✦ *Subsurface scattering is often the turning point where a portrait shifts from 'good' to 'alive.' If you skip this step or make it too subtle, the face remains flat even if shadows and midtones are correct. Make it INTENTIONAL and visible — warm cheeks and a glowing nose tip are markers of health and life.*

09 Step 9: Lips & Mouth Definition

Upper and lower lips, mouth line, inner mouth shadow, nostril definition

Soft directional strokes following lip shape, feathering edges into surrounding skin, very light pressure for creases and line definition, sharp pencil point for detail.

Light to Medium pressure

- Lips are a separate plane with distinct value and temperature: the upper lip is darker and cooler, the lower lip lighter and warmer (it catches light). The lip line is soft and integrated into the face, never a hard outline — it is a transition, not a boundary.
- Upper lip — cool and darker: Apply PC1025 (Periwinkle) or PC926 (Carmine Red) at light pressure, defining the upper lip shape as a darker, cooler plane that recedes slightly. The line where the upper lip meets the rest of the face should be soft, feathering into surrounding skin with no hard seam.
- Lower lip — warm and luminous: Apply PC926 (Carmine Red) at medium pressure across the lower lip, keeping it noticeably warmer and more saturated than the upper lip. Add a touch of PC939 (Peach) or PC1080 (Beige Sienna) at ultra-light pressure to the brightest part of the lower lip (usually the central bulge) so it reads as catching light.
- Mouth line (between lips): A very soft shadow line, not a hard seam. Use PC1031 (Henna) or PC1081 (Chestnut) at ultra-light pressure to suggest the meeting point; this line should be almost imperceptible, more of a tonal shift than a drawn line.
- Inner mouth shadow (if the mouth shows any opening): A whisper of PC1099 (Espresso) or PC1025 (Periwinkle) at ultra-light pressure inside the mouth opening, recessed so the opening reads as a shadow, not a void.
- Lip creases (final refinement): Once all lip colour is set, use a sharp pencil point with PC1031 (Henna) or PC1099 (Espresso) at very light pressure to add ONE or TWO subtle horizontal creases across the lower lip, parallel to the lip edge. These are fine detail lines, not grooves; restraint avoids a creased or aged appearance.

COLORS

● PC1025 Periwinkle

● PC926 Carmine Red

● PC939 Peach

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1081 Chestnut

● PC1099 Espresso

↔ PC926 (Carmine Red) is the lip colour base; PC1030 (Raspberry), PC1014 (Deco Pink) or PC1001 (Salmon Pink) work similarly. PC1025 (Periwinkle) cools the upper lip; PC1099 (Espresso) or PC1031 (Henna) work as cool-toned lip lines. Avoid pure grey or ashy tones.

STOP WHEN

The upper lip reads as a distinct, cooler plane; the lower lip glows warmer and is noticeably lighter, with a soft integrated mouth line · the crease strokes are fine and light, gliding without resistance, leaving paper texture visible.

✦ *Lip rendering fails most often by making lips too dark, too saturated or too outlined. Real lips are soft and integrated into the face; the upper lip should be noticeably darker than the lower lip (portrait anatomy rule), and the brightest part of the lower lip should sit at the light's peak, not evenly across the lip.*

IO Step 10: Edge Hierarchy, Detail Refinement & Lash Line Accent

Lash line and eye area (focal accent), face outline, hair-to-background edge, garment stripe detail

Crisp short strokes for lashes, sharp pencil point, directional strokes for fold definition, feathering and soft pressure at margins, deliberate edge loss into background.

Medium to Heavy for focal lash line, Light everywhere else pressure

- Edge hierarchy controls focus: hard edges advance and grab attention, soft edges recede. Reserve the SHARPEST edge for ONE focal area — the upper lash line — then ACTIVELY LOSE edges everywhere else outward into background, shadow and hair.
- Lash line (the focal accent): Darken the upper lash line with PC1099 (Espresso) or PC1025 (Periwinkle) at medium-heavy pressure, using a sharp pencil point to define individual lashes as a cluster of short, upward strokes. This is the darkest dark on the face and the most crisp edge; the lower lash line stays softer and diffuse, never mirroring the upper. Add a soft touch of PC1025 (Periwinkle) or PC926 (Carmine Red) at ultra-light pressure at the inner eye corner (where tears would pool), reading as a warm pink or cool shadow.
- Face outline — deliberately soft: The silhouette edge of the face (jaw, cheekbone margin, forehead edge) should be deliberately soft — feather or LOSE it into the background or hair, never render it as a hard line. Where the face meets the neck, keep the transition soft and gradual. A hard outline makes the portrait look like a mask; soft edges make it read as three-dimensional form.
- Hair-to-background edge: The hair should partially merge or LOST into the background. Do not frame the entire head with crisp curls; instead, let some sections blend into the background and other sections show crisply against a contrasting background tone. This variation in edge quality makes the hair read as soft and natural.
- Garment details — define without overworking: Refine the stripe placement and crisp the colour boundaries between white, blue and orange sections. Any visible folds or shadow in the fabric should be suggested with soft contour lines (not harsh outlines) using cooler or darker shades of the garment colour.
- Overall assessment — step back and squint: The eye should be drawn to the lash line and inner eye corner first, then allowed to wander via softer edges. If the gaze is trapped or bounces around, edges need adjustment.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1025 Periwinkle

● PC926 Carmine Red

● PC1100 China Blue

● PC1102 Blue Lake

⇔ PC1099 (Espresso) and PC1025 (Periwinkle) are the dark lash lines; use whichever reads darker in your palette. For garment folds, use darker shades of the garment colour (deeper blue, deeper neutral) rather than introducing new hues.

STOP WHEN

The lash line is dark and crisp; the eye is the focal point and draws the gaze first · all other facial edges are soft and diffuse, blending into background or shadow; garment stripe boundaries are defined but soft.

✦ *Edge hierarchy is the most commonly skipped step because it feels like 'finishing,' but it is actually the linchpin of a successful portrait. A portrait with perfect colour and value but uniform edge hardness looks stiff and two-dimensional. Commit 15 minutes to LOSING edges deliberately — feather, blend, soften — and the portrait will suddenly read as three-dimensional and professional.*

II Step 11: Final Burnish, Peak Highlights & Wax-Bloom Correction

Entire face with selective burnish, peak highlights on lit planes, then wax-bloom management

Heavy pressure circular strokes for burnishing, gentle wiping for bloom removal, medium-pressure directional strokes for shadow reinforcement, sharp pencil for peak highlights.

Heavy for burnish, Light-Medium for dark reinforcement pressure

- Burnishing melts wax layers into a smooth, painted finish and closes paper tooth — but it LIGHTENS values and causes wax bloom (a hazy white migration on the surface). This is the final pass and must be managed carefully to preserve luminosity.
- First — selective burnish on lit planes only: Using PC914 (Cream) or PC938 (White) at HEAVY pressure, burnish ONLY the lit planes and highlight zones (forehead, upper cheekbones, nose bridge, lower lip, upper chest). Use circular strokes and repeat until the paper tooth is completely closed and the pigment appears solid and smooth. DO NOT burnish shadows, the eye area, or the cap — these need to retain depth.
- Second — peak highlights (optional, selective): Once the lit planes are burnished smooth, a few burnished highlights can be layered on top using PC938 (White) or PC914 (Cream) at very heavy pressure ONLY on the absolute brightest points (forehead apex, nose tip, cheekbone peak). These are final accents — one or two per face, maximum — and must be razor-sharp and small.
- Third — wax-bloom lift and correction: Wax bloom appears as a hazy white sheen across burnished areas. Gently wipe the entire face with a clean, soft cloth or soft brush to remove loose bloom. If bloom is heavy, a light coat of workable fixative can be applied (this artist does NOT use solvent). Accept a subtle bloom as a natural part of the finish.
- Fourth — punch final darks for depth restoration: After burnishing and bloom correction, the entire face will have lightened slightly. Go back into the shadows (especially the core shadow, eye socket and under-jaw shadow) and layer PC1099 (Espresso) or PC1025 (Periwinkle) at medium pressure to restore depth. The face should now read luminous yet dimensional.
- Do NOT overwork at this stage. Restrain yourself to two or three passes of dark reinforcement; over-burnishing and over-correcting collapses the luminosity you just built.

COLORS ☒ PC914 Cream ☐ PC938 White ☐ PC1099 Espresso
☒ PC1025 Periwinkle

⇔ PC914 (Cream) and PC938 (White) are both appropriate for burnishing lit zones; use whichever is on hand. PC1099 (Espresso) and PC1025 (Periwinkle) reinforce shadows; any

dark colour works, but stay warm-toned in core shadows and cool-toned in peripheral shadows.

STOP WHEN

The lit planes are completely smooth and glossy with bright sharp peaks and full dimensional depth in shadows · the burnish pressure was heavy enough to close the tooth and light enough to avoid crushing delicate highlights.

✦ *This is where many portraits are lost. Heavy-handed burnishing flattens the portrait and locks in any muddy blending from earlier. Burnish selectively — ONLY the lit planes — and leave shadows and mid-tones unburned so they retain depth and dimension. If you over-burnish and the face becomes flat, use a colourless blender at very light pressure or lightly scrub in the direction of form to restore texture.*

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.